



Projecting the Archive: Bryan Forbes at 100

Whistle Down the Wind

Whistle Down the Wind

Directed by: Bryan Forbes

©: Beaver Films

a Beaver film

Made for: Allied Film Makers

Produced by: Richard Attenborough

Associate Producer: Jack Rix

Location Adviser: John Hargreaves

Production Secretary: Ann Skinner

Assistant Director: Basil Rayburn

Continuity: Penny Daniels

Casting: Maureen Goldner

Screenplay by: Keith Waterhouse, Willis Hall

From an original novel by: Mary Hayley Bell

Photographed by: Arthur Ibbetson

Camera Operator: David Harcourt

Editor: Max Benedict

Assistant Editor: Tom Priestley

Art Director: Ray Simm

Assistant Art Director: Len Townsend

Wardrobe: Laurel Staffell

Make-up: Geoffrey Rodway

Hairdressing: Stella Rivers

Music Composed and Conducted by:

Malcolm Arnold

Sound Recordist: Bill Daniels

Sound System: Westrex Recording System

Dubbing Editor: Alastair McIntyre

Made at: Pinewood Studios

uncredited

2nd Assistant Directors: Charles Blair,

Henry Emery

3rd Assistant Director: Stephen Christian

Assistant Continuity: Lorely Farley

Focus Puller: John Alcott

Clapper Loader: Ken Coles

Grip: Ted Lockhart

Stills: Harry Gillard

2nd Assistant Editor: Paul Smith

Whistler on Soundtrack: Richard Attenborough

Boom Operator: Gus Lloyd

Publicity: Diana Hawkins

Cast:

the adults

Bernard Lee (*Bostock*)

Alan Bates (*Arthur Alan Blakey, The Man*)

Norman Bird (*Eddie*)

Diane Clare (*Miss Lodge, Sunday school teacher*)

Patricia Heneghan (*Salvation Army girl*)

John Arnatt (*Superintendent Teesdale*)

Elsie Wagstaff (*Auntie Dorothy*)

Hamilton Dyce (*Reeves, the vicar*)

Howard Douglas (*Weaver, the vet*)

Ronald Hines (*P.C. Thurstow*)

Gerald Sim (*Wilcox, detective*)

Michael Lees (*1st civil defence worker*)

Michael Raghan (*2nd civil defence worker*)

May Barton (*villager*)

the children

Hayley Mills (*Kathy Bostock*)

Diane Holgate (*Nan Bostock*)

Alan Barnes (*Charles Bostock*)

Roy Holder (*Jackie*)

Barry Dean (*Raymond*)

the disciples

Christine Ashworth

John Boden

Doreena Clark

Keith Clement

Pamela Lonsdale

Judy Ollerenshaw

Robert Palmer

+ Q&A with actors Hayley Mills, Diane Poole and Alan Barnes

Bryan Forbes's first feature as director, *Whistle Down the Wind* is undoubtedly a 'classic', if that word denotes a film that continues to enchant audiences over 60 years after its making, and which still resonates with those who saw it at an impressionable age. It evokes a certain time – both of life and in history – yet it bears few direct traces of the early months of 1961 when it was made. It's also a film that is difficult to pigeonhole into a particular genre.

The film follows the three Bostock children, Kathy, Nan and Charles, who live on a farm in rural Lancashire with their father and aunt. One night, Kathy discovers a man in their barn and, hearing him utter the words 'Jesus Christ', concludes that he is the son of God. She convinces her siblings of his identity and they look after him, unaware that he is actually Arthur Alan Blakey, a suspected murderer on the run.

In telling this story, *Whistle Down the Wind* makes exceptional use of non-professional child actors, whose naturalness and 'rightness', both in relation to character and setting, lend it a unique charm. Their naive logic and plain speaking imbue their interactions with an endearing humour, through which the film subtly exposes and challenges the hypocrisy of the adult world. In this way, its outward simplicity conceals complex ideas and themes that deserve exploration.

The screenplay of *Whistle Down the Wind* bears the traces of the various hands that contributed the ingredients and moulded it into its final shape. The creative input came from two contrasting worlds: Mary Hayley Bell, wife of actor John Mills and centre of a cultural clique (of which producer Richard Attenborough and Forbes were also a part), and the more instinctively realist (and humanist) vision of Yorkshire-born writing partnership Keith Waterhouse and Willis Hall. These seemingly opposing worlds produced something that transcended the constraints and potential of both, creating a film with wide appeal to an audience spanning age and class.

Forbes later remarked, 'given the eleventh-hour atmosphere, I have never ceased to be amazed at the ease with which the film went together', crediting Attenborough's hard work and efficiency, which is attested to by the correspondence in his personal archive housed at the University of Sussex. From scouting the area in early December 1960 to the start of filming on 13 February 1961, the team completed the selection and preparation of locations, cast both professional and non-professional actors, and organised accommodation, equipment, transport and the construction of a production village in a field near Worsaw End Farm, in the Pendle Valley, Lancashire.

The film's final cost was £154,026, more than £10,000 under budget, and it was completed on schedule. *Whistle Down the Wind* was a financial and critical success for producers Allied Film Makers, as was Basil Dearden and Michael Relph's 1961 release *Victim*, and the two films found themselves in competition with each other for selection as the British entry to international film festivals.

The London trade show for *Whistle Down the Wind* was on 19 July 1961 and it received effusive reviews in the British press. From *The Guardian's* headline

Lois Read
Nigel Stafford
the latecomers
Anne Newby
Julie Jackson
UK 1961©
99 mins
35mm

Brand new 35mm print made in 2026 by the BFI National Archive at Haghefilm, Netherlands. The soundtrack was scanned by the BFI National Archive and restored by Molinare, London. Restoration supported by Simon and Harley Hessel.

Whistle Down the Wind by Josephine Botting is available to buy instore and online from the BFI Shop: <https://shop.bfi.org.uk/whistle-down-the-wind-bfi-film-classics-paperback/>



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'Just Short of Genius' to Peter Burnup's *News of the World* write-up – 'I found myself held in enchantment from beginning to end. See it as soon as you can' – the critics had no hesitation in recommending the film both for its artistic and entertainment merits. Alexander Walker was a particular fan, describing it as 'a shining, humorous, touching, truthful British film.'

There was plenty of praise for Forbes's handling of both the narrative and the non-professional cast, *Tribune* opining that he 'certainly possesses gifts, conspicuous in the British cinema by their absence', while Paul Dehn in the *Daily Herald* called it a 'modest British masterpiece ... brilliantly direct[ed]'. There was praise for Forbes's 'sensitive and showmanlike direction', and Patrick Gibbs in *The Daily Telegraph* noted his 'eye for the countryside and ... magic touch with the children'.

American critics were equally positive when it opened across the Atlantic in April 1962. 'One of the most enjoyable and heartwarming films we've ever seen', wrote Bosley Crowther in *The New York Times*. There was a strong sense that its 'Englishness' was a major element of its appeal, Richard L. Coe noting that 'Forbes has developed each scene with beautiful reticence ... there are scenes of exquisitely soft, country England beauty', 'reticence' clearly being deemed a national trait. In contrast, *The Hollywood Reporter* highlighted the 'tart and humorous screenplay ... [that] handles a difficult subject with discipline and insight'.

That the critics found many different aspects of the film praiseworthy is testament to the range of talent and creativity brought together for its production. The acting, direction, writing, cinematography and music were all singled out by reviewers, as were its effective creation of 'that secret world of childhood' and its allegorical qualities. The fact that the former was achieved without a trace of mawkishness and the latter without offending religious audiences was attributed to Forbes's skill as a director.

Extracted from *Whistle Down the Wind* by Josephine Botting (BFI Film Classics, 2026)

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The League of Gentlemen + intro by Mark Gatiss
Sun 6 Sep 14:40

Seance on a Wet Afternoon + intro by writer and producer David McGillivray
Tue 8 Sep 18:00

The L-Shaped Room + intro by author and journalist Cathi Unsworth
Tue 15 Sep 18:00

The Wrong Box + intro by Nanette Newman
Tue 22 Sep 18:15

King Rat + intro by Sarah Standing, Bryan Forbes' daughter
Tue 29 Sep 18:00

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